Official Rules & Regulations

Imagine Cup

2026 Season

Version 2
Last updated December 2025

1. Overview

Imagine Cup is Microsoft's springboard for student founders who seek to build commercially viable solutions using Microsoft's cloud and AI platforms.

To compete, a submission must use at least two Microsoft AI services.

Submissions must include:

- Completed responses to all questions in the application form, detailing the team's experience in building technical solutions.
- A pitch deck that includes a demo video of the team's minimum viable product (MVP).
- A video recording of the team's pitch.

These materials must collectively address the judging criteria outlined in this document.

2. Sponsor

These Official Rules ("Rules") govern the operation of the Microsoft Imagine Cup competition ("Competition"). Microsoft Corporation, One Microsoft Way, Redmond, WA, 98052, USA, is the Competition sponsor ("Sponsor"). Replit, Inc., ("Replit") is a Partner for this Competition, and is contributing to the promotion, administration, and execution of this Competition. Microsoft and Replit are the "Competition Parties".

3. Definitions

In these Rules, "Microsoft", "we," "our," and "us" refer to Sponsor and "you" and "yourself" refers to a Competition entrant, or the parent/legal guardian of any Competition entrant who has not reached the age of majority to contractually obligate themselves in their legal place of residence. By entering, you (your parent/legal guardian if you are not the age of majority in your place of legal residence) agree to be bound by these Rules.

4. Competition schedule

This Competition starts at 00:00 Coordinated Universal Time ("UTC") on September 30, 2025 and ends in May 2026. It consists of up to three (3) rounds with two (2) paths for entrants: one path for the Launch teams and one path for the Scale teams (as described in Section 5 (Eligibility) below) participating in the MVP Round and Semifinals Round. Only Scale teams are eligible to advance to the World Championship Round.

More details on the eligibility for Launch and Scale paths provided later in these Rules.

Final dates for the Semifinals and World Championship rounds will be communicated to eligible entrants via email.

Round	**Start date (all times 00:00 UTC)**	**End date (all times 23:59 UTC)**
Minimum Viable Product Submission Round ("MVP")	September 30, 2025	January 9, 2026
Semifinals Round ("Semifinals")	February 10, 2026	April 7, 2026

World Championship Round ("World Championship")	April 2026*	May 2026*

*the specific dates will be communicated to the teams following the Semifinals via email.

You must submit an entry to the MVP Round to be eligible to advance in the Competition.

5. Eligibility

You are eligible to compete if you meet the following requirements below at time of entry, which is defined as the most recent date you have submitted an entry into a specific round.

- **You are** at least 18 years of age as of September 30, 2025; **and**
    - If you are 18 years of age or older but have not reached the age of majority in your legal place of residence, then you must have consent of a parent/legal guardian.
- All team members must be enrolled students at an accredited educational institution that grants high-school or college/university (or equivalent) degrees (including home schools) at any time between September 30, 2025 and May 31, 2026; **and**
- **You are NOT** a resident of Cuba, Iran, North Korea, Sudan, Syria, Russia, and the Region of Crimea; **and**
    - U.S. export regulations prohibit the export of goods and services to Cuba, Iran, North Korea, Sudan, Syria, Russia, and the Region of Crimea. Therefore, residents of these countries/regions are not eligible to participate.
- Paths. Upon entering, the Competition entrants will select which path is applicable to their business as of January 9, 2026, based on the criteria below. Sponsor reserves the right to reassign a team at any time prior to April 7, 2026 as a Launch or Scale business based on the information provided in the application, or which otherwise becomes available to Sponsor. Participants in each path will compete against the other participants in their path.
    - **Launch path:**
        - **You/your business has not** received any dilutive funding **and**
        - **You/your business has not** received external, non-dilutive funding of more than $100,000 USD.
    - **Scale path:**
        - **You/your business has** not received more than $5,000,000 USD in combined dilutive or external, non-dilutive funding.
- **You are not** an employee or intern of Microsoft Corporation, Replit, or an employee of either of the Competition Parties respective subsidiaries, at any time between September 30, 2025 and May 31, 2026; **and**
- **You are not** involved in any part of the execution or administration of this Competition; **and**
- **You are not** a previous winner of the Imagine Cup; **and**
- **You are not** an immediate family member of (parent, sibling, spouse/domestic partner, child) or household member of an employee of one of the Competition parties, their respective subsidiaries, or a person involved in any part of the administration and execution of this Competition between September 30, 2025 and May 31, 2026.

Microsoft Student Ambassadors who meet the eligibility criteria set forth above may enter the Competition but cannot use any resources which are not broadly available to all other students in connection with the creation or execution of an entry. This includes using Microsoft property, internal resources, Student Ambassador benefits, and/or the work of Microsoft employees. If you have any questions, please reach out to the Community Program Manager.

This Competition is void outside the geographic area described above and wherever else prohibited by law.

6. How to enter

- Register on the Imagine Cup website and create your team. Teams will choose either the Launch or Scale path, based on criteria listed in the Eligibility rules above. Additional criteria on teams are listed in the Teams and Mentors section provided later in these Rules.
- Follow the submission requirements listed below.
- To submit an entry, visit the Imagine Cup website and follow the instructions to submit your entry.
- Unless otherwise specified, submission requirements are identical for both Launch and Scale paths.

7. Submission requirements

The following criteria apply to all Imagine Cup submissions:

- Your product must be built with and require at least two (2) or more Microsoft AI service(s) to operate. Microsoft AI service(s) include but are not limited to Azure AI Foundry and Azure Machine Learning.
- All submission materials, including your pitch deck materials, recorded videos of your pitch and demo, and live presentations during judging rounds, must be in the English language. While your product may support multiple languages, English must be one of the represented languages.
- All submissions will be evaluated by Microsoft, our designated agent, or a qualified judging panel (except for submissions in the Semifinals Round, in which a single judge on the judging panel will be selected by Replit and the rest will be selected by Microsoft) using the relevant competition round judging criteria provided later in these Rules.

8. Competition details

Below is a description of each competition round and the associated submission requirements. To be eligible, an entry must meet the following requirements for the applicable round.

You are encouraged, but not required, to align your solution with one of these five (5) categories:

- Cybersecurity
- Education
- Finance
- Health and Life Sciences
- Retail and Consumer Goods

These categories spotlight some of the most urgent and impactful challenges facing institutions today. While entries that address these categories are more likely to be successful, solutions that fall outside these areas may also be considered at the discretion of the Sponsor.

You may only submit one (1) entry per competition round. We will disqualify any incomplete or illegible entries that we receive or entries that we determine do not meet the above criteria in our sole and absolute discretion. We are not responsible for entries that we do not receive for any reason or for entries that we receive but are not decipherable for any reason. Any attempt by you to obtain more than the stated number of entries by using multiple/different accounts, email addresses, identities, registrations, logins, or any other methods will void your entries and you may be disqualified. Use of any automated system to participate is prohibited.

8.1 MVP Round – (See Minimum Viable Product (MVP) Submission for additional details)
Build a functional version of your solution ("Minimum Viable Product" or "MVP") that demonstrates customer validation, market fit, and reflects thoughtful consideration of diversity and inclusion. Your MVP must be ready for a demo to judges and include sufficient features and functionality to satisfy early adopters.

To compete in the MVP round, teams are required to submit the following materials by January 9, 2026 to explain what you have built. These materials must collectively address each of the MVP round judging criteria provided later in these rules.

(1) Pitch Deck: a slide presentation that you will use to present your startup. It must include how your team has defined the problem and how your team has validated your assumptions with real customers (see judging criteria for MVP round on Founder-led validation and continuous improvement). We recommend referencing How to pitch your company – module on Microsoft Learn when building your pitch deck.

Your deck must meet the following criteria:

- Your deck must be no more than 15 slides, including an appendix. The file must be in PPT, PPTX, or PDF format. You must include your solution architecture and a comprehensive list of the Microsoft technologies used.
- The solution that you pitch must be fully functional and demonstrable to judges within your demo video (more information below).
- The file must be no larger than 100MB. You may compress your document into a ZIP file for submission.

(2) Recorded Videos: a 3-minute pitch video and a 2-minute demo video of your Minimum Viable Product. Both videos must meet all criteria:

- You must provide publicly accessible URLs where the video files can be viewed by judges. We suggest sharing the video via Microsoft OneDrive or other public video hosting platforms. Do not password protect the files.
- You may **not** edit the video in any way except to trim the beginning and/or ending so the video only includes the pitch or demo itself.

- Each video file must be no larger than 100MB. You may compress each file into a ZIP file for submission.
- While only registered team members may participate in the recorded videos, it is not a requirement that all team members be present in the videos.

  Pitch Video: a 3-minute maximum video that records your team pitching your startup as if you were pitching live to judges/investors.
    - Your video must simulate the experience of a judge viewing your pitch.
    - Place your video camera where a judge might sit and then record your pitch to the camera.

  Demo Video: a 2-minute maximum narrated video that records your team showing the functional version of your solution that demonstrates application of Microsoft AI services and how someone uses your product. This video should mimic a live demo.

Optional: Interactive Prototypes: you are welcome but not required to share interactive, high-fidelity prototypes using a prototyping tool (e.g., Figma, Axure) to show your MVP's functionality and the experience the user will have. These prototypes should mimic the functionality and interaction of the product you are demoing and will be shared during the technical review should you progress to the world championship.

Generate a direct link to your prototypes that is publicly available for judges to review. Do not password protect the prototypes and disable any commenting features if possible.

- Figma instructions for how to create direct link to prototypes
- Axure instructions for how to create direct link to prototypes

8.2 MVP Round Advancement

Teams in the MVP round will be evaluated by judges using the MVP judging criteria provided later in these rules. The MVP round will result in a minimum of seven (7) teams that will advance to the Semifinal round. This will be communicated no later than February 13, 2026.

8.3 Semifinals Round

A minimum of fifteen (15) teams and a maximum of twenty-five (25) (as decided by Microsoft in its sole and absolute discretion) will be selected from all eligible entries to compete in the Semifinals, including at least four (4) teams from the Launch path and at least four (4) teams from the Scale path. The remaining semifinalists will be determined by the Sponsor based on the MVP round judging criteria. This will include a minimum of seven (7) teams and which were selected from the MVP round evaluation process, and a minimum of eight (8) teams from identified university entrepreneurship programs, which will be selected based on an evaluation process with the same judging criteria as the MVP round.

Teams are required to participate in the following activities and submit the following materials, which must collectively address each of the Semifinals judging criteria provided later in these rules.

5-week Program

Upon selection as a semifinalist, a team will receive notice of the five (5)-week training

program ("Training Program"), and must confirm their commitment to fully participate in the Training Program within the time specified in the notice. The Training Program is designed to accelerate their growth, including technical enablement, mentorship, and opportunities to refine their solution and product-market fit, and will provide tailored support to address the needs of both Launch and Scale startups. Participation means dedicating approximately one (1) hour per week to attending scheduled sessions, utilizing provided resources and technical support, and actively engaging with mentors and subject matter experts.

If a team selected as part of the semifinals cannot confirm their full participation, the Sponsor reserves the right to offer their place to an alternate team.

Technical Review
Microsoft may perform a one-time technical review on Semifinalist entries that it concludes, in its sole and absolute discretion, do not adequately describe the Microsoft AI services used, to be conducted by Microsoft experts. This review aims to ensure that the submitted solutions are authentic and fully functional. You will be asked to walk through and explain your complete solution and architecture so that experts can verify its capabilities and ensure that it meets submission criteria. If the experts determine that an entry does not meet the submission criteria, the entrant will be given an opportunity to correct their entry prior to the Live Pitch and Demo.

Live Pitch and Demo
A five (5)-minute maximum presentation that will be given live to a panel of judges. The five (5)-minute allotment will include your core pitch about your startup as well as your working demo. This will be a refined version of the pitch and demo that you submitted to the MVP round.

- Your demo may be live or pre-recorded with live narration.
- You are responsible for your product to be fully installed on suitable hardware for your demo.
- You are responsible for procuring a translator if needed for your live presentation. Microsoft cannot serve as translators for your team.

8.4 Semifinals Round Advancement

Teams in the Semifinals round will be evaluated by judges using the Semifinals judging criteria provided later in these rules.

For both Launch and Scale startups, the judging criteria will include an assessment of the team's engagement and utilization of the resources provided during the 5-week program. Teams are expected to demonstrate how they have applied feedback and support to improve their solution.

The Semifinals will result in three (3) Scale startups advancing to the World Championship.

While Launch startups do not advance to the World Championship, judges will select one (1) first place Launch team who will win $50,000 USD, as provided in Section 10 (Prizes).

No other team rankings will be released. The winner of the Launch path and the Scale path entrants advancing to the World Championship round will be communicated no later than April 10, 2026.

8.5 World Championship Round

The World Championship is the culmination of the competition, where three (3) Scale teams continue to hone their solution and pitch with additional mentoring.

Live Pitch and Demo

The final pitch may take place virtually or in person, with the top three Scale startups presenting live to a panel of judges who are experts in their respective field. Competitors must have the same materials prepared as required in the Semifinals round, which is outlined above. At least one (1) member of the team must be present for the World Championship virtually or in-person if applicable to compete for the prize.

Winning the World Championship

Teams in the World Championship round will be evaluated by judges using the judging criteria provided later in these Rules. Judges will select one (1) first place team. No other team rankings will be released.

9. Winner selection and notification

Submissions are reassessed at each stage based on the most recent version submitted or presented.

Judging Criteria – MVP Round

Criteria	Description	Weighting
Founder insight, market viability, and inclusive design	**How clearly has the team defined a unique and compelling problem?** Judges will assess how the team has: • articulated a real, urgent, and original problem, supported by initial market research and identified customer segments. • shown thoughtful consideration of diversity and inclusion in the solution's design and intended impact. • shown the team's unique strengths and founder-market fit. • provided a robust, data-driven go-to-market plan targeting enterprise customers.	30%
Founder-led validation and continuous improvement	**Has the team engaged with real users or customers to validate their assumptions?** Judges will look for: • credible evidence of user engagement.	30%

	• clear examples of how feedback has informed early iterations of the solution.	
Use of Microsoft Technology	**How effectively has the team applied Microsoft's cloud and AI platforms to build a robust, scalable solution?** Judges will evaluate: • how meaningfully the team has leveraged Microsoft AI services (such as Azure OpenAI, Azure AI Studio, or Cognitive Services) in a way that is core to the solution's value proposition. • a brief technical summary and a demo of the MVP or prototype, clearly showing Microsoft AI in action.	40%

Judging Criteria - Semifinals and World Championship Rounds

Criteria	Description	Weighting
Founder insight, market viability, and inclusive design	**How has the team demonstrated that their solution is feasible, scalable, and ready for large scale deployment, with a clear vision for market disruption and growth?** Judges will assess: • the team's unique founder insight or experience that positions them to lead in their chosen space. • the solution's potential to disrupt or redefine the market, and its feasibility and scalability for mass consumer or enterprise use. • a robust, data-driven go-to-market plan. • whether diversity and inclusion is a core part of the team's identity and strategy. • how diversity and inclusion principles are reflected in both the product features and the team's go-to-market approach.	30%
Founder-led validation and continuous improvement	**How has the team achieved and evidenced market traction, including growth metrics, customer testimonials, and ongoing iteration based on real-world feedback?** Judges will look for: • evidence of sustained progress and market traction supported by strong growth metrics (such as MAU/DAU, paying customers, revenue, or investment; AND/OR case studies, testimonials, or actioned feedback from real users or customers). • ongoing iteration and validation showcasing the most significant customer validation or feedback.	30%
Use of Microsoft Technology	**How has the team delivered an enterprise-grade solution that leverages Microsoft AI as a true competitive advantage?** Judges will assess:	40%

	• depth of Microsoft AI integration and technical sophistication to address customer and enterprise challenges. • deployment of new or advanced Microsoft AI services. • architecture or technical overview highlighting AI components and improvements in scalability, reliability, or security.	

For the World Championship, each entry will receive a score based on some or all of the criteria mentioned above. There may also include a public voting element. Exact criteria, including the voting process and any limitations, will be published before the World Championship. If public voting is used to help determine scores, it is strictly prohibited to obtain votes through fraudulent or inappropriate means, such as offering prizes or other incentives in exchange for votes, using automated programs, or creating fraudulent IDs. Microsoft reserves the right to void any suspicious votes.

In the event of a tie between any eligible entries, an additional judge will break the tie based on the judging criteria mentioned above. The judges' decisions are final and binding. If we do not receive enough entries meeting the entry requirements, we may, at our discretion, select fewer semifinalists or winners than the number of Competition Prizes described below.

10. Prizes

Fifteen (15) – Twenty-five (25) Semifinalist Teams: The semifinalists will receive a prize package consisting of the following:

- A free one (1) year subscription to Microsoft Azure for Startups with $25,000 worth of credits. Approximate Retail Value (ARV) $25,000.00 USD.
- A free Replit Teams account with up to four (4) sign-ins (one (1) per team member) for three (3) months with $1,000 USD worth of credits (To be awarded by Replit). Approximate Retail Value (ARV) $1,120.00-$1,480.00 USD.

  The Total Approximate Retail Value (ARV) of this Prize Package is between $26,120.00-$26,480.00 USD.

One (1) Launch Path Winner: In addition to the Semifinalist prize, the Launch path winner will also receive a prize package consisting of the following:

- A cash prize of $50,000 USD. Approximate Retail Value (ARV) $50,000.00 USD.
- An additional three (3) months on their Replit Teams account with an additional $1,000 USD worth of credits (To be awarded by Replit). Approximate Retail Value (ARV) $1,120.00-$1,480.00 USD.

  The Total Approximate Retail Value (ARV) of this Prize Package is between $51,120.00-$51,480.00 USD.

Three (3) Scale Path Finalists: In addition to the Semifinalist prize, the Scale path finalists will also receive a prize package consisting of the following:

- An additional six (6) months on their Replit Teams account with an additional $5,000 USD credits (To be awarded by Replit). Approximate Retail Value (ARV) $5,240.00-$5,960.00 USD.

  The Total Approximate Retail Value (ARV) of this Prize Package is between $5,240.00-$5,960.00 USD.

One (1) Scale Path World Champion: In addition to the Scale Path Semifinalist prize and the Scale Path Finalist prize, the Scale path winner will also receive a prize package consisting of the following:

- A cash prize of $100,000 USD. Approximate Retail Value (ARV) $100,000.00 USD.
- An additional six (6) months on their Replit Teams account with an additional $5,000 USD credits (To be awarded by Replit). Approximate Retail Value (ARV) $5,240.00-$5,960.00 USD.
- A mentorship call with Microsoft Chairman and CEO Satya Nadella.
- Potential opportunities for deeper partnership with Microsoft for Startups.

  The Total Approximate Retail Value (ARV) of this Prize Package is between $105,240-$105,960.00 USD.

The total Approximate Retail Value (ARV) of all prizes awarded in this Competition is between $563,880.00 - $837,360.00 USD, depending on the number of team members in each winning team.

All prize money will be divided equally among each officially registered member of the team or the incorporated business (at the winner's choice), paid out via electronic transfer to the registered member's and/or business bank.

All prizes are stated in U.S. dollars, but we, or our local subsidiary or designated agent (on our behalf), may award a cash prize in the official currency of the winner's country of residence based on the exchange rate on the date of payment.

If you are confirmed as a winner:

- You may not exchange non-cash prizes for cash or any other merchandise or services. However, if for any reason an advertised prize is unavailable, we reserve the right to substitute a prize of equal or greater value; **and**
- You may not designate someone else as the winner. If you are unable or unwilling to accept your prize, we may award it to the next highest scoring team/entrant; **and**
- Taxes on the prize, if any, are the sole responsibility of the winner, who is advised to seek independent tax counsel regarding the implications of accepting a prize; **and**
- By accepting a prize, you agree that the Competition Parties may use your entry, name, image and hometown online and in print, or in any other media, in connection with this Competition without payment or compensation to you, except where prohibited by law; **and**
- If you are otherwise eligible, but have not reached the age of majority in your legal place of residence, then we may award the prize to your parent/legal guardian on your behalf; **and**

- Unless otherwise noted, all prizes are subject to their manufacturer's warranty and/or terms and conditions; **and**
- Mentors of winning teams are not awarded any cash prizes in association with their participation in this Competition.

Notifications

- Teams advancing to Semifinals and World Championship rounds will be posted as a blog post within seven (7) days following judging. Individual team members advancing will be notified via the contact information provided during entry. If we require you to accept an invitation to compete further or claim a prize, and the notification is returned as undeliverable or you are unreachable, we may disqualify your team and invite the next highest scoring team/entrant.
- The winners will be announced no later than the end of June 2026.
- In case of a dispute regarding the identity of an entrant, we will consider the entrant to be the authorized account holder of the email address provided during entry. The "authorized account holder" is the natural person assigned to an email address by an internet or online service provider, or other organization responsible for assigning email addresses.
- If you are selected as a semifinalist, you will need to sign an Affidavit of Eligibility, Liability and Publicity Release. Any entrant receiving a cash prize will be required to submit a W-9 tax form (for U.S. residents) or W-8BEN tax form (for non-U.S. residents) within the deadline stated in the winner notification.
- If you have not reached the age of majority in your legal place of residence, your parent or legal guardian may need to sign all required forms on your behalf.
- If you do not complete and return the required forms within the specified time period, we may disqualify you and invite the next highest scoring team/entrant.
- If the World Championship takes place in person, you will be responsible for obtaining a valid passport and any necessary visas, along with any associated expenses incurred to procure them. Microsoft will provide a formal invitation letter to assist with the visa process. If in-person travel applies, any expenses not explicitly listed by Microsoft are the sole responsibility of the entrant. If you live within 250 miles of the travel destination, we reserve the right to substitute alternate transportation for air travel. Event dates and locations are subject to change at our sole discretion, so you must have flexible travel capabilities. Travel is subject to availability and must be completed on dates specified by Sponsor or advancement will be forfeited and awarded to the next highest scoring team/entrant. No cancellation or transfer of reservation is allowed after they have been made.

11. Teams and mentors

Up to four (4) eligible students may submit a single entry as a team. Team members may come from different academic institutions and different countries.

- Each competitor may belong to only one team within the competition.
- You may receive assistance with your solution from additional students in specific disciplines beyond the four registered members of your official team and/or from a mentor (typically from academic institutions, not-for profit organizations, or private companies). Additional students and mentors are not considered team members for

purposes of these rules. They will not be eligible for any prizes, included in any aspect of the competition rounds or the World Championship award ceremony, or recognized in official communications such as press releases. Only the up to four team members you officially register with us are eligible for prizes, award ceremony inclusion, and official communications.

- To compete, each team member must create an account at ImagineCup.com and register for the competition. Once registered, any team member can create a new team and invite the remaining team members to join. The remaining team members must accept the invitations before the MVP submission deadline to be recognized as qualified team members.
- If at any time during the Competition you become ineligible after you've submitted an entry, please proactively remove yourself from your team via your ImagineCup.com profile and cease participating. If it is found you've continued to contribute to your team's entry after becoming ineligible, your team may be disqualified.
- If your team is invited to participate in the Semifinals and/or the World Championship, at least one member of your team must attend either virtually or in-person, depending on format. If your team is unable to attend virtually and/or in-person for any reason, we may disqualify your entire team and invite the next highest-scoring team to participate.
- Each team is solely responsible for its own cooperation and teamwork. In no event will Sponsor officiate any dispute regarding the conduct or cooperation of any team or its members.

The intent and spirit of the Competition is to evaluate and showcase the skills and creativity of the student entrants. Anyone acting as a team mentor, or in any mentorship role, where allowed, must limit their support to general guidance. They must not contribute in any way that could be considered original authorship or that could enable claims of rights or ownership to the submitted entries. Under no circumstances will work on behalf of teams or individuals be allowed.

12. General standards for entries

In addition to the requirements listed above, all entries must meet the following general standards:

- Your entry must be your own original work. The video must be solely the work of the team, including but not limited to, the actual filming, editing, graphic design, etc. of the video; **and**
- You must have obtained all consents, approvals, or licenses required for you to submit your entry; **and**
- To the extent that entry requires the submission of user-generated content such as software, photos, videos, music, artwork, essays, etc., entrants warrant that their entry is their original work, has not been copied from others without permission or apparent rights, and does not violate the privacy, intellectual property rights, or other rights of any other person or entity. You may include Microsoft trademarks, logos, and designs, for which Microsoft grants you a limited license to use for the sole purposes of submitting an entry into this Competition; **and**

- You must not have used Competition Parties respective property, internal resources, and/or the work of the Competition Parties employees, in connection with the creating your entry**; and**
- Your entry may NOT contain, as determined by us in our sole and absolute discretion, any content that is obscene or offensive, violent, defamatory, disparaging, or illegal, or that promotes alcohol, illegal drugs, tobacco or a particular political agenda, or that communicates messages that may reflect negatively on the goodwill of the Competition Parties.

13. Copyright

Your entire entry must only include material (including source code – both open source and third party sourced, user interface, music, video, or images) that you own or that you have permission to use from the copyright/trademark owner. Your entry will be disqualified if it includes copyrighted materials (such as source code, user interface, background music, images, or video) without appropriate licensing or permissions. If you use permissible copyrighted materials, you must include permissions information by citing the artist/creator and license information as per the Competition Rules. Note that even material released under sites such as Creative Commons, common open-source code licenses, and other similar licensing may need permission or acknowledgement as per the specific license. Note: your team's entry will be disqualified if permissions information is not included as per the requirements in the specific Competition Rules.

Health Related Solutions

If your entry includes health-related products or devices, you are solely responsible for obtaining any legal or regulatory clearances or approvals required to commercialize your entry. You are also solely responsible for the design, development, and implementation of your entry and for providing end users with appropriate warnings. You are solely responsible for any personal injury that may occur from the use of your entry, including (without limitation) any such injuries to end users. The Sponsor does not endorse, approve, recommend, warrant or guarantee, and provides no opinion, recommendation, or advice regarding the accuracy, integrity, quality, safety, efficacy, suitability, or use of entries, including but not limited to use of the entry for health, medical, or patient care purposes.

14. General conditions and release of liability

To the extent allowed by law, by entering you agree to release and hold harmless the Competition Parties and their respective parents, partners, subsidiaries, affiliates, employees, and agents from any and all liability or any injury, loss, or damage of any kind arising in connection with this Competition or any prize won.

All local laws apply. The decisions of the Competition Parties are final and binding.

We reserve the right to cancel, change, or suspend this Competition for any reason, including cheating, technology failure, catastrophe, war, or any other unforeseen or unexpected event that affects the integrity of this Competition, whether human or mechanical. If the integrity of the Competition cannot be restored, we may select winners from among all eligible entries received before we had to cancel, change or suspend the Competition.

If you attempt or we have strong reason to believe that you have compromised the integrity or the legitimate operation of this Competition by cheating, hacking, creating a bot or other automated program, or by committing fraud in any way, we may seek damages from you to the full extent of the law and you may be banned from participation in future Microsoft promotions.

15. Use of your entry

We are not claiming ownership rights to your entry. The Competition Parties do not take any equity in the businesses submitted to the Competition. All intellectual property rights for the entries remain with their respective owners. However, by submitting your entry, you grant us an irrevocable, royalty-free, worldwide right and license to use, review, assess, test, and otherwise analyze your entry and all its content in connection with this Competition and use your entry in any media whatsoever now known or later invented for any non-commercial or commercial purpose, including, but not limited to, the marketing, sale, or promotion of this Competition without further permission from you. You will not receive any compensation or credit for use of your entry, other than what is described in these Rules.

By entering, you acknowledge that we may have developed or commissioned materials similar or identical to your entry and you waive any claims resulting from any similarities to your entry**.** Further you understand that we will not restrict work assignments of representatives who have had access to your entry, and you agree that use of information in our representatives' unaided memories in the development or deployment of our products or services does not create liability for us under this agreement or copyright or trade secret law.

During and after this Competition, your entry may be posted on a public website. We are not responsible for any unauthorized use of your entry by visitors to this website. We are not obligated to use your entry for any purpose, even if it has been selected as a winning entry.

Personal data you provide while entering this Competition will be used by Microsoft and/or its agents and prize fulfillers acting on Microsoft's behalf only for the administration and operation of this Competition and in accordance with the Microsoft Privacy Statement.

If you do not want to grant us these rights to your entry, please do not enter this Competition.

16. Governing law

This Competition will be governed by the laws of the State of Washington, and you consent to the exclusive jurisdiction and venue of the courts of the State of Washington for any disputes arising out of this Competition.

These Rules do not, nor do they purport to, limit, exclude or modify any non-excludable statutory guarantees as provided under the *Competition and Consumer Act 2010 (*Cth*)* or any other warranties (whether express or implied) under any Australian state or federal legislation which cannot be excluded.

17. Winners list

A list of final winners will be published as a blog post by June 30, 2026.